

Lesson 22: The Word of Wisdom: “A Principle with Promise” (See L22 [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us understand how we can avoid deception and apostasy.

President Gordon B. Hinckley: “I recall a bishop’s telling me of a woman who came to get a [temple] recommend. When asked if she observed the Word of Wisdom, she said that she occasionally drank a cup of coffee. She said, ‘Now, bishop, you’re not going to let that keep me from going to the temple, are you?’ To which he replied, ‘Sister, surely you will not let a cup of coffee stand between you and the house of the Lord.’” (Ensign, May 1990, 51)

- Daniel 1:1-2, 3-17.

1. Why was the Word of Wisdom revealed?

†1. Brigham Young

- 1 Corinthians 3:16-17; 6:19-20. A clean, pure body affects us spiritually.
- D&C 89:4. “conspiring men”

How is the Word of Wisdom a manifestation of God’s love for us?

How is it a manifestation of Joseph Smith’s calling as a prophet and seer?

2. The Lord’s counsel about what is not good for the body.

Lesson Manual: Avoid discussion of health fads, special diets, and other kinds of food and drink. Emphasize that the Lord has not specified everything that we should and should not partake of.

- D&C 89:5-9. In addition: a) illegal drugs, b) any other habit-forming substances except under the care of a competent physician, c) misuse of prescription and other drugs.

What are some of the physical and spiritual consequences?

James O. Mason: “Each year tobacco use causes approximately 2.5 million premature deaths worldwide. Tobacco use also harms millions of innocent victims. For example, smoking by pregnant mothers passes on toxic chemicals that interfere with fetal development, afflicting approximately 3 million babies each year. These babies have lower birth weight and increased risk for neurological and intellectual delays and for premature death. Other innocent victims include nonsmokers who regularly inhale secondhand smoke. These people have much higher rates of respiratory illness and are three times more likely to die of lung cancer... Smokeless tobacco is just as addictive as cigarettes, and users of smokeless tobacco have cancer rates up to fifty times higher” (“I Have a Question,” Ensign, Sept. 1986, 59–61)

†2. A 14-year selective study conducted by UCLA epidemiologist

†3. CNN news article in 2000

How can seemingly small violations of the Word of Wisdom be damaging?

How can parents effectively teach their children about the Word of Wisdom and help them obey it?
(*Family Home Evening Resource Book [31106]*, pages 228-31)

3. The Lord’s counsel about what is good for the body.

- D&C 89:10-17.
- 88:124. “Cease to be idle” †4. Brigham Young
- 59:15-21. “And inasmuch as ye do these things with thanksgiving,”
- 49:19, 21. “And wo be unto man that sheddeth blood or that wasteth flesh and hath no need.”

4. Promised blessings for obedience to the Word of Wisdom.

- D&C 89:3, 18-21. †5. President Heber J. Grant †6. Elder Boyd K. Packer
- †7. Social scientists †8. Tattoos and unusual body piercing

How have you been blessed as you have obeyed the Word of Wisdom?

Next Week: L23: “Seek Learning, Even by Study and Also by Faith”; See L23 [Class Member Study Guide](#).

(You can download a free LDS Institute manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).) † •

†1. **Brigham Young:** "The first school of the prophets was held in a small room situated over the Prophet Joseph's kitchen, in a house, which belonged to Bishop Newel K. Whitney, and which was attached to his store... In the rear of this building was a kitchen... Over this kitchen was situated the room in which the Prophet received revelations and in which he instructed his brethren. The brethren came to that place for hundreds of miles to attend school in a little room probably no larger than eleven by fourteen. When they assembled together in this room after breakfast, the first they did was to light their pipes, and, while smoking, talk about the great things of the kingdom, and spit all over the room, and as soon as the pipe was out of their mouths a large chew of tobacco would then be taken. Often when the Prophet entered the room to give the school instructions he would find himself in a cloud of tobacco smoke." (*Journal of Discourses*, 12:158)

†2. **A 14-year selective study conducted by UCLA epidemiologist** James E. Enstrom tracked the health of 10,000 moderately active LDS people in California and ended in 1987. Of these non-smoking, monogamous non-drinkers, Enstrom concluded from the study "that LDS Church members who follow religious mandates barring smoking and drinking have one of the lowest death rates from cancer and cardiovascular diseases—about half that of the general population. ... Moreover, the healthiest LDS Church members enjoy a life expectancy eight to eleven years longer than that of the general white population in the United States."

(⁵⁶In Wikipedia; Enstrom, JE. (1989 December). "Health practices and cancer mortality among active California Mormons". *Journal of the National Cancer Institute* 6:81 (23): 1807–14. PMID 2585528]

†3. **A CNN news article in 2000 related the results of a study on caffeinated soda pop (excerpts below):**

"Most people cannot taste the difference between caffeinated and non-caffeinated sodas, according to a new study, even though soft drink manufacturers say they add caffeine to enhance flavor.

"The Johns Hopkins study found that only 8 percent of a group of 25 adult consumers were able to detect the caffeine in sodas. The rest could not tell the difference between caffeinated and non-caffeinated drinks until caffeine levels were raised to levels beyond those approved by the Food and Drug Administration.

"Soft drinks represent the single largest source of added sugar in the U.S. diet, according to sources cited in the study. Soda drinking displaced consumption of more nutritional foods and could lead to more tooth decay, obesity and bone fractures, the report said...

"Soda makers responded to a 1981 FDA proposal that caffeine be eliminated from cola drinks by saying it enhanced flavor." (in GDC)

†4. **Brigham Young:** "Instead of doing two days' work in one day, wisdom would dictate to [the Saints] that if they desire long life and good health, they must, after sufficient exertion, allow the body to rest before it is entirely exhausted. When exhausted, some argue that they need stimulants.... But instead of these kind of stimulants they should recruit by rest." (*Discourses of Brigham Young*, sel. John A. Widtsoe [1941], 187)

†5. **President Heber J Grant:** "No man who breaks the Word of Wisdom can gain the same amount of knowledge and intelligence in this world as the man who obeys the law. I don't care who he is or where he comes from, his mind will not be as clear, and he cannot advance as far and as rapidly and retain his power as much as he would if he obeyed the Word of Wisdom." (CR, Apr 1925) (in GDC)

†6. **Elder Boyd K. Packer:** "I have come to know ... that a fundamental purpose of the Word of Wisdom has to do with revelation.... If someone 'under the influence' [of harmful substances] can hardly listen to plain talk, how can they respond to spiritual promptings that touch their most delicate feelings? As valuable as the Word of Wisdom is as a law of health, it may be much more valuable to you spiritually than it is physically." (*Ensign*, Nov. 1979, 20)

†7. **Social scientists** have found that Church members who live the gospel, including the Word of Wisdom, are more likely than others to be happy in their marriages and satisfied with their family life. They are less likely to engage in premarital or extramarital sex, to experience depression, and to be involved in delinquent, deviant, or antisocial behaviors. (See Robert L. Millet and Noel B. Reynolds, eds. *Latter-day Christianity: 10 Basic Issues* [booklet, 1998], 46-47)

†8. **Tattoos and unusual body piercing:** The Apostle Paul taught that our bodies are holy to the Lord and that they are temples in which the Holy Ghost can dwell (1 Corinthians 3:16; 6:19-20). Just as we should not defile our bodies by partaking of harmful substances, we should not defile their external surface with tattoos or unusual piercing. Such modifications can have negative physical, social, and spiritual consequences. (See David A. Burton, "I Have a Question," *Ensign*, Feb. 1999, 52-53)